

II. ANTHROPOLOGICAL BASIS FOR PERSONALIST ETHICS

Theme 4. The person as author of behaviour

- We have seen that Ethics is closely related to the person because it studies the morality of his free human actions, through which he develops his own way of being and his own personal history.
- As a result we can say that every ethical theory has an anthropological basis which touches on the truth about man.
- In order to be able to study Ethics, we need to have a good knowledge of the human being: what is man? How does he act? What role does freedom have in his activity?
 - On the basis of this knowledge, we can afterwards carry out an ethical reflection on how man's moral life should be in order to grow and develop according to who and what he is.
- Although last year you studied the anthropological basis for Ethics, we now need to review and to consolidate some ideas in order to continue, later on, with Ethics II as such.

The acting person

- There is a great difference between animals and human beings; even though both are living creatures, only man is a person.
 - The animal comes into existence with a given nature which determines its way of acting; animals act on instinct or through having been forced to learn something.
 - However, the human being has been created with a free nature which is capable of knowing and loving; this means that man has to learn how to do nearly everything, he doesn't know by instinct what to do or how to act.
 - He has to learn to walk, to eat, to drink, to speak, to read; he has to learn how to live as the person he is.
- What does the term "person" mean? It comes from the Latin *personare*, which means "to sound" or "to resound". In the Roman theatre the word was used to indicate the masks which the actors wore and which functioned like megaphones, making the voice of the artist resound so that he could be heard.
 - With time, "person" was used to indicate the role played by the actor and which he would make known or manifest through the mask.

- One of the most well known definitions of the term “person” is that of the Roman philosopher from the 5th century, called Boethius; he defined person as:
 - “An individual substance of a rational nature”².
 - “individual substance”: something which exists in and by itself (not relying on anything else to exist such as the white or the green needs the writing board in which they can exist as accidents); it is a whole and undivided thing in itself, and it exists separately from other things; a car, a computer.
 - ⇒ In a certain sense, it is absolute in as much as it doesn’t need other things in order to exist.
 - ⇒ As an individual, it is an existential unity which is different from other things of the same species.
 - ⇒ For example: a table = a whole thing which doesn’t depend on anything else; it is different from the other tables, even though they have exactly the same shape, colour, etc.
- However, not all individual substances are persons; the table is not a person. What makes the individual substance be a person? According to Boethius, it is the fact that the substance is of a rational nature; that is, it has the capacity for self-conscious, reflective and abstract thought.
 - Because the person has a rational nature, he has a particular essence or way of being which makes him capable of reasoning, of inferring, so that, from understanding some known thing, he can come to grasp or know some unknown thing.
 - Rationality distinguishes the way of being of the person from that of other individual substances.
 - ⇒ Rationality makes the way of being of the person different from the way of being of another individual substance, such as a chair.
 - So, being a person means being a subject (individual substance) of a rational nature whose most significant property is that of being he himself the internal source of his own free decisions.
- Generally, man is said to be made up of two components: body or matter and soul or spirit.
 - But it is more correct to say that the human person is composed of two co-principles which constitute or give rise to one composed reality (a unity).

² *De duabus naturis*, ch. 3, PL 64, 1343.

- So, rather than saying that man has a body and has a soul, it is more correct to say that man is completely body and soul.
- The person, which is a single substance, is constituted by body and soul; they are not two different real things which are juxtaposed; rather, together they constitute the single and one human person.
- The soul is that which makes the person be a human person and it converts the matter into a living human body with its capacity to move, feel, and understand.
 - So body and soul are not two different things which exist by themselves and unite to form the person; rather, man is a material body whose principle or determining factor which makes it be a human body, is the soul, in perfect unity of body and soul.
 - Thanks to the soul, man is essentially and qualitatively different to and superior to the animals; he is a unique and unrepeatable being with full ethical responsibility for the outcome of his own life.
 - If we do not take into account the soul, it is difficult to understand the human being's superiority and the absolute respect which the person merits; no really human anthropology can be done without taking into consideration the soul.
 - ⇒ The underlying dignity of the person resides in the soul which informs the body.
- The human person is not just a body, although externally he may seem so; rather, the human person is the perfect synthesis of body and soul which forms one whole nature through which all human acts are carried out: feeling, knowing, loving, deciding, speaking, etc.
 - Due to the internal unity of the human person in the individual substance, it is not just the eyes that see and the tongue that taste, or the intellect that thinks or the will that decides.
 - Rather, it is the whole person that sees through the eyes, and thinks through the intellect, etc.
 - So the person is aware that his body belongs to him and is part of his person; he is aware that it is not just something external things "stuck onto him".
 - Experience shows that the person's interior world is revealed through the body; through the body, the human person reaches out of himself and opens up to the world around him, made up of people and things.
 - It is through the body that the human soul enters into contact with the material, sensitive world and can come to know it and think about it.

- Thanks to the body, the person makes himself known to others and communicate with them; the look, the word, the smile, the tears, are all bodily expressions of the personal soul; the whole person reveals himself through these gestures.
- Because of this we can say that in the human being the materiality of the body and the spirituality of the soul are perfectly integrated.
- This substantial unity of body and soul, which also reveals itself in a person's activity, is very important for Ethics; this is because every human act is fruit of the unity between body and soul, so every human act involves an interior intention (soul) and external realization (body).
 - The free act of the human being is made up of these two aspects: intention and carrying out.
 - The human being carries out many acts and activities, however, those which are most proper to him as a person are knowing and freely choosing, because there the intellect and the will intervene; these are the superior faculties in the human person which distinguish him from the animals.
 - The person will achieve perfection if he knows the truth and loves what is good because these are the final goals of the intellect and the will.
- Now we will study the way in which the human being reveals himself through his activity because it is the whole person as such that carries out those free, moral acts.

Anthropological analysis of the human act

- The human being comes into the world with his particular way of being which involves in itself great perfection.
 - We have said before that the person has an immense dignity and value due to the fact of being made of body and soul; the smallest new born baby, therefore, is infinitely more valuable than the most perfect animal (lion, elephant, dog).
 - ⇒ For this reason, abortion is so wrong: it involves killing an innocent human being.
 - However, the baby has not yet reached the complete development and degree of perfection that man can attain, thanks to his body and his soul.
 - Thanks to his free human acts, the person can grow and develop, coming closer to complete personal self-fulfillment.
 - ⇒ Here we are not speaking of physical development only; we are referring to the growth of the person as a whole, in body and soul.

- In a certain sense we can say that the person is a being who has never finished growing; just as the person reveals their personal being through their acts, those acts contribute to developing further that personal way of being.
 - The possibilities for further growth are unlimited; as long as the person lives in time and space and can act freely, he can always grow and improve, becoming an ever better person.
 - Hence we see there is a close link between the way of being of the person and the activity of that person; they mutually influence one another thanks to the unity between body and soul.
 - The activity of the person reveals or makes known the person, with their good qualities and their bad habits; in order to understand and know the person we need to consider their acts.
 - By studying particular human acts, we can get to know the specific person; by studying the structure of human acts in general, we can get to know how a person reveals himself in his acts and this can bring us to the anthropological basis of Ethics.
- We have already seen that human acts are those which are carried out freely, and in a rational way, based on reflection; it is precisely through his intellect and his will that the person controls and dominates his own actions.
 - This free, voluntary act, can be described as: the act that proceeds from an intrinsic principle, with formal knowledge of the goal.
- General part of the definition: proceeds from an intrinsic principle
 - ⇒ This is the first determining element in the voluntary act; it means that the act has its origin in the faculty of the subject which has an appetite, which tends towards something; this is the will (intrinsic principle).
 - ⇒ The voluntary act which has its origin in the will, is obviously different from those other acts which the person may carry out moved by force or violence, which are external to the person and make him act against his will; against what he would freely choose to do.
 - ⇒ The voluntary act is also different from the spontaneous act which has its source in an intrinsic principle of the person which does not possess formal knowledge of the goal of that act.
 - ⇒ Here we are referring to those vital processes and instinctive actions which come from the person, but are carried out spontaneously, without thought, reflection and a full and free decision.
 - ⇒ These are, in fact, what we have called the acts of man: eating, digesting, etc.

- Specific part of the definition: knowledge of the goal.
 - ⇒ This is the second determining element in the voluntary act; this means that before choosing freely and acting, the person knows the goal which he wishes to attain through this act.
 - ⇒ The person consciously and actively determines to act (thinks and decides to act) after having evaluated (reflected on) the convenience (goodness or not) of acting.
 - ⇒ Hence, the goal sought is somehow the source of the act (moves the person to act so as to achieve it); this goal is the object towards which the will tends (the good thing which attracts the will).
 - ⇒ The human act is teleological; it tends towards an end, a goal (telos).
 - ⇒ Every act which is deliberated on (thought about), and executed (carried out), aims at achieving a particular end, goal; there is an intention (aim) behind the act, moving the person to act in this way.
 - ⇒ Even animals act in order to achieve a goal, or end, but they do so moved by instinct or some natural tendency (survival); for this reason, they are not free and rational in tending towards that goal; they do not “choose” it in the strict sense of the word as there is no freedom or deliberation which moves them towards that goal.
 - ⇒ Only rational beings, creatures, can propose an objective to themselves for their action, and act freely in order to achieve that goal
- We will now discuss this issue more deeply, under the title of the “intentionality” of the will.

The voluntary act as an intentional act

- Intentionality is a characteristic of the acts of the intellect and the will by which the act is open to, is directed towards achieving some goal.
- The will is the faculty with which, guided by the intellect, the person decides what he wants; he has the intention of gaining a goal.
- Characteristics of the intentionality of the will³:
 - Conscious: before action, it is the person who plans and represents the act; he himself, as a result of knowing the goal, establishes consciously, in an aware way, the connection between the act and the goal he wants to achieve; projecting and representing are acts of the intellect which are implied in the voluntary action; each person has the experience that he himself is the author (source) of his own acts.

³ Cf. RODRIGUEZ LUNO, A., *Etica general*, Eunsa, Pamplona 1991, p. 120.

- Active: the person and the goal to be attained enter into relationship with one another through the initiative of the person.
- Guided and ordered by reason: the intellect presents the intentional object to the will, that is, the act or the object which the will wants; the rational judgment establishes the motive which unites the act to the goal: I want to do this act because it is good, or, because it is useful, etc.
- Self-referential: every voluntary act has its goal (intentional object), but it also has the person himself as its goal because the act carried out reverts to the person, refers to and effects the person who carries it out.
 - ⇒ A person cannot rob (steal) without becoming he himself a robber (thief).
 - ⇒ The fact that the voluntary act reverts on the person who carries it out, is a characteristic of the act of the will; it is not the case with the acts of the intellect. Although I may know about a robbery, this knowledge does not convert me into a robber, it does not make me morally responsible for the act of robbery.
- We are saying, then, that every free human act has repercussions in the person who carries it out; it modifies the person one way or another⁴; this is because to want something implies a personal evaluation of the wanted thing which does not occur in the case of the act of knowing.
 - The person becomes committed as a person through each of his free acts; when a man decides on something, he is not only choosing some object which is outside himself, rather his decision brings along with it, self-determination; the person determines himself in some way through that decision.
 - ⇒ In every free act, man does not just carry out an act which has external effects, he is actually realizing himself or making himself as a person.
 - ⇒ For this reason we can say that the person, with his free acts, determines himself, possesses himself and dominates himself in as much as he can freely decide to act in a given way or he can decide freely not to act in that way.
 - ⇒ He actually possesses himself through every free act because every free act is self-referential; it refers back to the person who carries it out because he wants this act as something that belongs to him as a person.
 - ⇒ So every free act really modifies the person in an accidental way but in a way which affects the whole person.

⁴ Cf. POLO, Leonardo, *El conocimiento habitual de los primeros principios*, Eunsa, Pamplona 1993, p. 55.

- ⇒ This is so because when a person wants something, in that free act he is claiming for himself, seeking for himself, the wanted things, he wants it for himself and so he becomes tied up in the act of wanting.
- ⇒ So to freely want, desire something dishonest, for example, makes the person who wants it dishonest because he claims it for himself with his free wanting, he wants it for himself⁵.
- The self-referentiality of the voluntary act is very important in Ethics because each person is, in a certain sense, what he has done through his actions; the moral value of the acts remains inside the person (immanent).
 - It is because of this that we can say that man is capable of changing himself and of achieving perfection through his acts.
 - Through each of his free acts, man realizes (fulfills) himself, expresses himself and also comes to be himself.
 - Being a person is not something already pre-defined forever; we are always on the way to being more or less a person, depending on our free acts through which we “dominate” ourselves, make ourselves what we are.
 - “The development of the humanity of each man depends on his way of acting. If the acts did not influence his way of being, if they did not leave an imprint, if they did not modify or perfect the human dimension of each person, man would not be a being who is open to his own essential growth”⁶.
 - As persons, we have the task of each day tending, through our actions, towards the perfection of our personal being.

Direct and indirect object of the will

- Now we need to consider what it is that moves the will to freely choose one thing or another; in other words, we need to study the object of the will.
- In itself, the human will is open to any good; precisely, the act of the will is the inclination towards a known good thing.
 - The object of any faculty is that which makes it work or act; the object of hearing is sound so that when there is a sound, actual hearing takes place.
 - The object of the will is whatever makes it will freely; anything that the intellect knows to be good, can move the will to want it; the direct object

⁵ Cf. RODRIGUEZ LUNO, A., *Op. cit.*, p. 121.

⁶ POLO, Leonardo, *Ética: hacia una versión moderna de los temas clásicos*, Colección AEDOS, Unión Editorial, Madrid 1887, p. 91.

of the will (which puts it into action) is the good thing because it is good, that which the intellect understands to be good for the person.

- The will can be moved by anything good; a good thing can be wanted in and for its own sake (as an end in itself), or as a means to achieve a goal.
- If something is willed in itself, as a goal it can be for one of these reasons:
 - It is an honest good: an objectively good thing which is worthy of being loved or wanted; somehow the person recognizes himself in that good and he approves of it (he sees it is good for him as a person).
 - Delectable good: wanted because it produces a positive affective response; be it pleasure, satisfaction, joy, etc.
 - Useful good: something which is wanted not in itself, but rather as a means or instrument to achieve a goal (honest or delectable good).
- As we have said, the direct object of the will is the good perceived or understood by the intelligence; the will can also have an indirect object or effect, which may or may not be willed in itself.
 - An indirect effect is a consequence of an action which is not willed in itself at all, neither as a goal nor as a means, but rather is simply foreseen and permitted as inevitably linked to what is willed directly.
 - For example: a person may need to receive quimotherapy to overcome or cure a cancer (this is the direct object: cure); however, the secondary effect will be baldness.
 - ⇒ This indirect effect is not wanted in itself, but it is a necessary consequence of what is willed directly and so must be tolerated.
 - A woman who would like to have children and so form a family may need to have the womb removed due to cancer and as a result she will be sterile.
 - ⇒ Direct object: cure the cancer.
 - ⇒ Indirect object: remove the womb and become sterile⁷.
- Now we need to see how the intellect intervenes in the free act.

The link between knowing and willing in human acts

- As we have said, every human act is carried out through the will which has been enlightened by the intellect; when we act, intellectual knowledge and the assent of the will cross over and influence each other.

⁷ RODRIGUEZ LUNO, A., *Op. cit.*, p. 132.

- When a decision has to be made the internal act of the will requires an intellectual process in order to determine how the person will decide; now we shall study this process in order to see how the acts of the will and those of the intellect interrelate.
- S. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*, I-II, q. 16, a. 1:

➤ ACTS OF THE INTELLECT	ACTS OF THE WILL
First apprehension of goal	Simple volition
Judgment on the goal	Intention
Deliberation about means	Consent
Judgment for choosing	Choice
Command (Imperio)	Active use of will Passive use of other faculties Enjoyment or fruition
- Through the first apprehension of the goal, the intellect knows and proposes the good thing to the will; this intellectual act is followed by the agreement of the will, known as simple volition or love; it is a first form of love for the goal in itself, without considering the means to achieve it.
- The next stage involves evaluating the possibility and ways of attaining the goal; if the means are considered to be insufficient for achieving the goal, the act of the will stops as it is not possible to get what it desires.
- As a result of this consideration, the intellect formulates a judgment which evaluates whether the goal can be achieved and the will adheres to this evaluation through the intention (clear wish to achieve the goal).
- Moved by the will, the intellect deliberates about the right means to achieve that goal, which the will may or may not accept (consent).
- Through the judgment for choosing, the most appropriate means which can be put into effect immediately, are identified; the will takes the internal decision to put that means into effect through choice which is an act that is proper and specific to the will.
- When the person has decided what he will do, the next step is to organize the activity of the various operative faculties (through the rational command), and the will moves the other potencies, compelling them to carry out the act.
- When the goal has been achieved, the will enjoys the possessed good.

- As can be seen, the intellect and the will are united from the start to the finish of the act because they are complementary faculties whose acts are present one in the other.
 - They are different faculties due to their different objects (intellect = truth; will = good) but they unite in their source which is the person.
 - Knowing and loving make up the immanent activity of the human soul.
 - Each free human act, therefore, has a rational and a free dimension which go to make up one act of the whole person.
 - As the human act is one, a unity, we need to see how the will, intellect and other potencies can configure the behaviour of the entire person.

The different human acts

- Human activity is rich and complex, hence it is impossible to classify all human acts; however, from the point of view of their morality (goodness or badness), human acts may be considered from different angles.
- Internal or external:
 - Internal: carried out inside the person – compassion towards another.
 - External: carried out using external organs – help the person in a specific and external way.
 - Both types of acts presuppose a free decision by the human being and, hence, they have moral value and qualify the person from the moral viewpoint.
- Good, bad or indifferent:
 - Good: the object chosen coincides with an honest good which perfects the person.
 - Bad: the chosen object goes against the good of the person and the moral order.
 - Indifferent: object is neither good nor bad nor has a moral connotation (walking); in reality, all free acts have a moral value which comes from the intention with which the person carries out the apparently indifferent act.
- Elicited or commanded:
 - Elicited: acts which the will produces independently of the body; to love, to hate, to plan something.

- Commanded: acts commanded by the will to a faculty other than itself; to the intellect = to read and understand; to a bodily organ = to the foot to walk or not to walk.
- The whole person, in body and soul, acts to achieve the goal desired by the will.
- Degree of voluntariness of the action; it depends on the way in which the will adheres to the good proposed to it by the intellect.
 - Perfectly voluntary: the person is aware of what they are doing and fully agrees with or consents perfectly to the act; there is full knowledge of the goal as such.
 - Imperfectly voluntary: imperfection in the knowledge of the goal (the person is not fully aware of what he is doing) or imperfection in how the will adheres to its object (lack of full consent).
 - ⇒ Lack of knowledge caused by situations which prevent the normal intellectual judgment implied in the act of the will at the moment in which the knowledge of the goal should inform the action: sleepiness, drunkenness, partial disturbance of the mind due to illness, great agitation, etc.
 - ⇒ Lack of full consent in the will caused by ambivalent situations which prevent the person from deciding = desiring and rejecting at the same time which produces a struggle: honest but painful act; pleasant but unethical act; economically good but unjust.
 - Involuntary: the goal is not known; the specific circumstances of the act are not known, in particular, the object is not known; evidently a person cannot be acting in a voluntary way if he does not know what he is doing; shooting arrows at a tree to practice the shot and hitting a person beside the tree who we didn't know was there⁸.
 - Mixed acts which are voluntary and involuntary at the same time: free and psychologically normal acts which a person carries out, but not moved by their free initiative; the person has to act in a difficult situation and overcome his repugnance because the act goes against his desires and he wouldn't do it if it were not for that extreme situation.
 - ⇒ Danger of shipwreck and need to throw all the merchandise overboard in order to save the people on the ship.
 - ⇒ Also called acts with a double effect, one of which is good and the other of which is bad; the good effect is wanted and the bad effect is

⁸ Cf. RODRIGUEZ LUNO, A., *Op. cit.*, p. 126.

rejected (indirectly voluntary because it is a consequence of the act which is voluntarily and directly desired).

- Voluntary acts apply to those we want or to the voluntary deed; but the term also applies to the acts of “not-wanting” known as acts of omission.
 - Omission: a voluntary act by which the person does not do something, either because he freely decides not to do something (elicited act) or because he simply abstains altogether from deciding and from acting.
 - In both situations the person is morally responsible for his voluntary inactivity because the abstention is the fruit of a free act of the will.
- The consideration of the different types of acts which the human being can carry out brings to light the role of freedom in the person who acts; this leads us to our next topic, a reflection on freedom in personalist ethics.